



Lady Fortitude: Delta Sigma Theta and the Promises of Suffrage

The Polk County History Center is partnering with the Lakeland Alumnae Chapter of Delta Sigma Theta to host an exhibit exploring the organization's impact on suffrage and the American landscape.

Founded on January 13, 1913, by 22 women at Howard University in Washington D.C., the sorority's first public act was to walk in the March 3, 1913, Women's Suffrage Parade. On that date, 25 Deltas, in their caps and gowns, marched with 1,000 university women from Bryn Mawr, Vassar, Wellesley, Smith, Goucher, George Washington, Radcliffe, Michigan, Swathmore and Cornell. In the century since their founding, Deltas have established a robust platform of programs to promote voter participation and to provide support for Black families internationally.

Florida's first Delta Sigma Theta chapter was the Beta Alpha chapter, founded at Florida A&M University on January 30, 1937. Currently, there are 17 collegiate chapters in Florida and 35 alumnae chapters including the Lakeland Alumnae Chapter founded in 1977. Among the notable Polk County Deltas are Louversa Thomas Herbert, a retired educator, and Fentrice Driskell, a member and Minority Leader of the Florida House of Representatives and a graduate of Polk's Lake Gibson High School.

The exhibit features historic photographs, heirlooms, such as the red "Lady Fortitude" statuette, and personal profiles to explore Delta Sigma Theta's impact in Polk County and beyond.

This community exhibit is in companion to the existing exhibit, "The 19th Amendment at 100 Years: A Milestone of Democracy for Women's Suffrage", at the Polk County History Center.

For more information, visit www.polkhistorycenter.org or call (863) 534-4386. The Polk County History Center is open Tuesday through Saturday, from 9 a.m. to 5 p.m. Admission is always free.